



OFFICIAL

NMHS MHS PROCEDURE

Management, Storage and Access to Psychology Test Protocols

Scope (Audience)	All NMHS Mental Health Services (MHS) Clinical
Scope (Area)	All NMHS MHS Departments of Clinical Psychology and Clinical Neuropsychology
Summary	Document outlines the requirement and process for managing, storing and accessing psychology test protocols for the North Metropolitan Health Service Departments of Clinical Psychology and Clinical Neuropsychology.
Risk Rating	Low
NSQHS Standards	Clinical Governance (Std 1)
Policy Sponsor	NMHS MHS Director of Strategic Projects
Policy Contact	NMHS MHS Area Health Information Manager
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COMPLIANCE WITH THIS DOCUMENT IS MANDATORY

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1. Aim

This document outlines the mandatory requirement and process for managing, storing and accessing psychology test protocols within North Metropolitan Health Service (NMHS) Mental Health Services (MHS) Departments of Clinical Psychology and Clinical Neuropsychology.

Note: This procedure **does not** provide guidance on other Psychology documentation (other than Psychology Test protocols) and whether that documentation should be stored separately to the main health service medical record. Individual services should decide what is appropriate to include in their clinical documentation of a service contact within their main health service medical record versus their separate departmental Psychology records.

Individual services should consider patient privacy and confidentiality when making such decisions and be aware that the Department of Health (DoH) Digital Medical Record (DMR) currently allows all DoH users with DMR read only and write access to view all DMR records across all WA Health Services.

2. Background

The Australian Psychology Society's Code of Ethics and associated ethical guidelines (2007) stipulate that Psychologists must not compromise the effective use of psychological tests, nor render them open to misuse, by publishing or otherwise disclosing their content to persons unqualified or unauthorised to receive such information. The raw data available on patient protocols and profiles are highly sensitive information, which can be misinterpreted and threatens the reliability of the test if available to the public.

The protocols are typically subject to copyright restrictions and have stipulated 'user qualifications'. In addition, there is an obligation under contractual law, between the Psychologist and test publisher, that they will not breach copyright or allow individuals with no Psychologist qualifications to access the tests or protocols.

Traditionally Psychology departments within NMHS MHS have maintained separate medical records to the main health service record. This procedure has been developed to provide guidance on which *Psychology test related information* can be added to a health service's main medical record (whether digital or paper based) and which documentation must be stored (and accessed) separately by individual Clinical Psychology and Neuropsychology departments for reasons of confidentiality, privacy and maintenance of the effective future use of those documents/test protocols.

The [Mental Health Act of 2014 \(WA\)](#) (MHA 2014) and the [Freedom of Information Act of 1992 \(WA\)](#) (FOI Act) both contain clauses that allow psychology test protocols to be exempt from release as part of a MHA 2014 or FOI Application for copies of patient medical records.

3. Risk

Non-compliance with these requirements is considered a serious breach of professional responsibilities. It would form reportable conduct to the Psychology Board of Australia and could result in conditions being placed on a psychologist's registration.

Non-compliance with this process will impact on the following risk categories:

Culture	☒	Organisational Development	☐
Emergency Management	☐	Policy & Legislative Compliance	☒
Fiscal Responsibility	☐	Quality of Patient Care	☐
Governance & Accountability	☒	Research & Innovation	☐
Information Communications Technology	☒	Staff Safety & Wellness	☐
Facility Management	☐	Workforce Planning	☐
Medical Equipment	☐	Other	☐

4. Key Points

Psychological test protocols and raw data of psychological and neuropsychological testing must be stored separate to the health service's patient medical record.

A summary report which incorporates the assessment results, interpretation and recommendations will be included in the health service's patient medical record (whether paper based or DMR).

Psychology test protocols stored separately to the main health service medical record must only be accessed by qualified Clinical Psychologists or Clinical Neuropsychologists as required for clinical management.

All of the above documents must be retained in accordance with the [WA State Records Act \(2000\)](#) and the [WA Health Information Retention and Disposal Policy](#).

5. Procedures

Any requests for access to psychological test protocols or raw test data must be directed to the relevant Psychology Lead or Senior Psychologist for the service. Data can only be accessed and released by a Clinical Psychologist or Neuropsychologist.

- Psychological and neuropsychological testing protocols and documents will be filed and stored securely and separately to the main health service medical record, in dedicated locked Clinical Psychology and Neuropsychology rooms or other identified secure storage areas within the health service. This must be a centralised storage system. Files should not be stored in individual staff filing cabinets as this can result in records becoming misplaced or inaccessible by members of the Psychology team.
- Clinical Neuropsychologists/Psychologists will maintain an index of the file locations of neuropsychological testing protocols on a secure database such as a spreadsheet and maintain an electronic backup copy of the file. To uniquely identify each patient, it is essential that the patient's Unit Medical Record Number (UMRN) is recorded with their personal details in this database. It is preferable that any testing protocols stored on a secure database are stored on OneDrive as OneDrive meets the security and risk management requirements for the [Department of Health Cloud Policy \(MP 0140/20\)](#).
- The neuropsychological test score summary sheet and neuropsychological report is electronically stored by the Clinical Neuropsychologists/Psychologists in stipulated secure locations that are maintained by the relevant Professional Lead of Clinical

Psychology/Neuropsychology. Copies of these documents should always be printed and stored with the paper-based Psychology Department record. The electronic copy of each document should be deleted from the database after 7 years, provided that a paper-based copy has been included in the Psychology Department record.

- When the Psychologist/Neuropsychology Department's office cabinets are full, these protocols will be sent to long-term storage locations (as part of the patient's Psychology Department record) with the endorsement of the relevant Psychology Service Lead/Head of Department. These records may be sent to off-site storage after 2 years of last contact with the service or longer if required, at the discretion of the Psychology Service Lead/ Head of Department.

5.1 Roles and Responsibilities

- The Psychology Service Lead/Head of Department is responsible for overseeing the storage, retention, access and disposal of Psychology records in accordance with the [WA State Records Act 2000](#) and the [WA Health Patient Information Retention and Disposal Schedule](#). This must be done in consultation with the NMHS Mental Health Manager of Area Health Information.
- The relevant Psychology Service Lead or Head of Department is responsible for monitoring the Neuropsychology database to ensure that:
 - Documents (test protocols and neuropsychological test score summary sheets) are retained on the database for at least seven (7) years following the last date of contact for adults.
 - Documents are retained on the database until a child reaches the age of twenty five (25).
 - Psychology and Neuropsychology records and test protocols are retained permanently for at least seven (7) years **after patient death** in accordance with the retention period for psychiatric records which is stipulated in the WA Department of Health MP 0144/20 [Information Retention and Disposal Policy](#). Exceptions do apply (some records must be retained permanently) so consultation must be sought with the Manager, Area Health Information before any records are destroyed. This consultation should be sought regardless of whether the records/tests are stored on a database, in a Digital Medical Record or as part of a paper based medical record).
 - Documents stored beyond the length of time specified in the [WA State Records Act 2000](#) are escalated to the Professional Lead of Clinical Psychology for disposal.

6. Compliance, Monitoring and Evaluation

Compliance with this procedure is mandatory. There are legislative obligations relating to this procedure where a statutory penalty may apply for non-compliance.

The Service Lead or Head of Department for Clinical Psychology/Neuropsychology will be responsible for monitoring compliance:

- Evaluation, audit and feedback processes.
- Requests for access to these records
- Storage and maintenance of the electronic records.

This procedure will be evaluated as required to determine its currency, relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, and sustainability. At a minimum, it will be reviewed three (3) years using a risk management approach in accordance with the [NMHS Policy Governance Framework](#).

7. Definitions

Terms	Definitions
Psychological Test Protocols	The physical written record of psychological test scores obtained during assessments that are typically on copyrighted and protected record forms.
Neuropsychological test score summary sheet	A brief summary document containing raw and standardised scores obtained during neuropsychological assessment.

Refer to [NMHS Policy Document Glossary of Terms](#) for any other frequently used terms

8. Related Documents

Legislation	• Freedom of Information Act (WA) 1992 • Commonwealth Privacy Act 1988
WA Health mandatory policies	• WA Health Patient Information Retention and Disposal Schedule • Information Retention and Disposal Policy MP 0144/20 • Information Access, Use and Disclosure Policy MP 0015/16 •
NMHS Policy documents	• Healthcare Record Management Policy • Healthcare Record Access, Use and Disclosure Policy • Management of FOI Applications Policy • Records Disposal procedure
NMHS MHS Policy documents	• Patient Confidentiality Guideline • Release of Patient Information Policy • Clinical Record Management and Storage Policy • Archiving of Clinical and Other Records or Documents Procedure
Other Resources	• Australian Psychological Society. (2007). Code of Ethics. Melbourne, Vic. • Australian Psychological Society. (2011). The management of patient /client privacy and confidentiality in public provider settings. • WA State Records Act 2000 [internet]. 2017 [cited 2021 Sep 01].

9. Document Control

Document Version Control			
Date	Version	Author	Notes
13/01/2026	V1.0	Manager Area Health Information MHS	Initial publication

This document can be made available in alternative formats on request for a person with a disability.

Within the Department of Health WA, the term Aboriginal is used in preference to Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander, in recognition that Aboriginal people are the original inhabitants of Western Australia. No disrespect is intended to our Torres Strait Islander colleagues and community.

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